mitacs
Bringing innovation into reach

Business Strategy Internship Proposal Template

INSTRUCTIONS

1. To fill out this template, download a copy to your computer and save as a Word document. You may need a copy of your completed proposal in Word format if your proposal requires any revisions, so make sure to save two versions: a Word version alongside a PDF copy.
2. Your project content should be at least 3-5 pages in length for one 4-6 month internship unit. Larger projects may exceed this page count.
3. Once complete, upload the PDF version of your completed proposal to the Mitacs online Registration and Application Portal (RAP).
4. **Do not modify or remove text or instructions** in each section/subsection **or reformat** this form in any way. A modified form will result in a delay in the internship evaluation process.
5. **All sections of the proposal form must be complete to be considered for the program.**
6. **Read the Application Guide (Appendix A) starting on page 4** and **Appendix B on page 6** to learn more about the selection criteria that will be used to evaluate your proposal.

DECLARATIONS

Mitacs **will not approve a BSI application** if the intern listed on the proposal has a position of ownership, employment, or influence over the daily operations of the partner organization. Interns with close family or intimate relationships with academic supervisors or employees of the partner organization are also ineligible. Any other real or perceived conflict of interest (COI) - for example, **past intern employment at the partner organization** - **must** be disclosed to Mitacs during the application process using the Intern Eligibility and Conflict of Interest Declaration Form. Academic supervisors must disclose any COIs through the Academic Institution Acknowledgement of COI(s) Form, and submit this documentation on behalf of their post-secondary institution when applying through the Registration and Application Portal (RAP).

Mitacs will first determine if BSI program rules are satisfied, and if so Mitacs will then review the COI to determine whether mitigations can be enacted to manage the COI. If a COI does exist, we suggest that you contact your Mitacs Advisor prior to starting an application to ensure that the participants in this project are eligible for the program. Please view the Mitacs Conflict of Interest Policy for more information.

PLEASE NOTE: Failure to disclose a COI will:

- **Delay the project evaluation process**.
- **Require submission of a COI mitigation approach** satisfactory to Mitacs before project work initiates or continues.
- **Risk forced withdrawal from the BSI program**, should a satisfactory mitigation plan not be reached.

Have any applicants declared a COI via the appropriate documentation? ☐ **Yes, an intern** ☐ **Yes, an academic supervisor** ☐ **No**

Please indicate if any of the below statements are true.

☐ One or more named interns self-declares as an Indigenous person.
☐ The partner organization is a for-profit organization with self-identifying Indigenous persons who hold 50% or greater ownership shares.
☐ The partner organization is a not-for-profit with board membership consisting of 50% or greater self-identifying Indigenous persons.
☐ The partner organization is a not-for-profit whose core mandate includes Indigenous community impact or serving Indigenous communities.

** If any of the above statements are true, your organization may be eligible for enhanced leveraging via the* Mitacs Indigenous Pathways Initiative*. Please check with your Mitacs Advisor for more information.*

Please select all the types of innovation you will significantly impact through your project. Refer to the following definition of innovation for further information: Defining innovation - OECD.

☐ Product innovation ☐ Process innovation ☐ Marketing innovation ☐ Organizational innovation

2. Project Details

2.1 PROJECT DESCRIPTION

2.1.a. Background (What problem needs to be solved?)

Provide an overview and describe the main activities of the partner organization. Explain the innovation challenge or improvement priority that the partner needs to solve. Specify how this project will help the partner organization address those challenges in a way that goes beyond day-to-day business operations/activities. Describe what kind of expertise is required to solve the problem.

The **[partner organization]** seeks to address the inefficiency and inconsistency of municipal land development processes, which have become major barriers to meeting Ontario's housing and infrastructure targets. Decades of fragmented municipal regulations have produced complex, unpredictable approval systems that increase costs, delay housing delivery, and undermine economic competitiveness.

The organization works with municipalities, developers, and policymakers to improve process efficiency and coordination in the land development system. The key innovation challenge is to map and harmonize development approval processes across Ontario's 29 largest municipalities. This will involve documenting the full applicant journey, identifying bottlenecks, and analyzing variations in timelines, costs, and requirements to develop evidence-based recommendations for reform.

This project goes beyond routine municipal operations by introducing province-wide, data-driven process mapping and analysis, activities that municipalities do not have the capacity or mandate to conduct individually. The work requires expertise in industrial engineering, process optimization, lean management, and stakeholder engagement to design a harmonized framework that maintains safety and environmental standards while streamlining approvals.

2.1.b. Objectives and Approach (How will the problem be solved?)

State the objectives for this project and explain how you plan to accomplish them. Enough detail should be provided so that it is clear whether the described approach is appropriate to achieve each objective. For projects with more than one intern, clearly explain which objective(s) each intern will work on.

1. **Comprehensive Land Development Process Documentation** – Map the complete development journey as experienced by applicants, identifying all touchpoints, documentation requirements, approval pathways, timelines, and decision-making authorities.

    a. *Interns 1 and 2* will focus on process documentation, drawing on municipal materials and interviews to capture the full applicant experience.

2. **Evidence-Based Process Optimization** – Identify inefficiencies, bottlenecks, and best practices using lean management principles to develop recommendations that maintain safety and environmental protections while reducing redundancies.

    a. *Intern 3* will support comparative analysis and bottleneck identification using the data gathered from process mapping.

3. **Harmonization Strategy Development** – Create a framework for streamlining and aligning land development processes while preserving local autonomy. This includes identifying opportunities for shared digital platforms and standardized documentation.

    a. *Intern 4* will help synthesize findings into harmonization strategies and prepare supporting materials for municipal and provincial consideration.

4. **Stakeholder Engagement and Validation** – Conduct structured interviews and consultations with developers and municipal staff to validate findings and ensure recommendations are practical and evidence-based.

    a. *Intern 5* will focus on engagement activities, coordinating surveys, interviews, and focus groups with municipal and industry stakeholders.

5. **Approach:**
   The project will employ **Value Stream Mapping (VSM)** and **customer journey mapping** to document applicant experiences, along with **swim lane process analysis** and **SIPOC methodology** to map how applications move between departments. A **comparative bottleneck analysis** will identify key delays and best practices across municipalities. All findings will be validated through engagement with both developers and municipal staff, culminating in a harmonization framework with evidence-based recommendations for improvement.

2.1.c. Timeline (Who will solve the problem and how much effort will be required?)

*Insert a timeline showing **which task(s)** will be performed **when**, and by **which intern** in order to achieve the objectives stated above (consider breaking this down by week for shorter projects or by month for longer projects via a Gantt chart). Ensure there are no gaps in the timeline and that the effort required to complete each task matches the amount of time allocated for each intern.*

The project will take place over 20 months and is organized into three main phases that align with the project's three objectives. Five interns will work collaboratively throughout, each contributing specialized skills to ensure steady progress across all objectives.

2.1.d. Deliverables (What does success look like?)

List the deliverables or tangible results *you expect from the project and identify which intern is responsible for it. For example, will you develop a new patent/prototype/product/service, business model, business process, or will you access new markets? Will the intern be expected to produce a report, evaluation, presentation, etc.?*

The following deliverables will demonstrate the success of this project:

- Comprehensive land development process documentation across Ontario's 29 largest municipalities.
- Value Stream Maps and customer journey maps of development processes from the applicant perspective.
- Swim lane process diagrams showing departmental handoffs, wait times, and approval dependencies.
- Comparative bottleneck analysis identifying dependencies and delays across municipalities.
- Best practice identification highlighting municipalities with superior performance metrics.
- A harmonization framework for standardizing land development processes across participating municipalities.

2.2 INTERNSHIP BENEFITS

2.2.a. Benefits and Impacts to Canada

If this project potentially impacts broader challenges that society or the industry faces, please describe how the project will help address these challenges. Why are these contributions important?

This project addresses one of Canada's most urgent challenges: the housing affordability and infrastructure development crisis. By mapping and harmonizing land development processes across Ontario's largest municipalities, the project tackles the fragmented and inconsistent regulatory systems that slow housing delivery and increase costs. Streamlining these processes will reduce development timelines, lower administrative barriers, and improve predictability for builders—directly supporting federal and provincial housing targets.

Beyond housing, the project strengthens Canada's economic resilience in a period of global uncertainty. Inefficient domestic systems have been identified as critical vulnerabilities amid international trade tensions and economic instability. By improving municipal coordination and eliminating process redundancies, the project contributes to national competitiveness, productivity, and long-term prosperity.

The evidence-based harmonization framework developed through this work will provide a scalable model for other provinces and territories, helping governments balance efficiency with accountability and sustainability. These outcomes advance Canada's ability to deliver housing and infrastructure more effectively, promoting economic growth, community well-being, and national sovereignty.

2.2.b. Benefits to the Intern(s)

Explain how participating in this project aligns with the academic studies of the intern(s). How is participating in the project expected to benefit their future career(s)? For example, will they expand their professional network, gain knowledge in a business context, or develop skills in problem-solving, communication, project management, creative thinking, etc.?

Participation in this project directly supports the academic development of interns studying in fields such as public policy, urban and regional planning, civil or systems engineering, public health, and data analysis. The project's focus on mapping and harmonizing municipal land development processes offers a practical application of research, policy evaluation, and process improvement skills often emphasized in these disciplines.

Interns will gain hands-on experience with methodologies such as Value Stream Mapping, swim lane analysis, and comparative benchmarking, strengthening their analytical and problem-solving abilities. They will also develop professional skills in stakeholder engagement through interviews, consultations, and collaboration with municipal staff, developers, and policymakers.

By contributing to evidence-based recommendations for process reform, interns will enhance their communication and project management skills while gaining exposure to intergovernmental collaboration and policy implementation. Participation in this project will also expand their professional networks across municipal, academic, and industry partners, positioning them for future careers in public administration, planning, infrastructure policy, and systems analysis.

2.3 INTERNSHIP ENVIRONMENT

2.3.a. Description of the Academic Internship Environment

*i. Please describe the nature of academic supervision during the internship period. Explain the **type and frequency of interactions** (e.g., meetings, phone calls, etc.) between the intern and academic supervisor.*

ii. Will the project make use of the resources and/or facilities of the academic institution? If so, please describe.

Interns will be supervised by **Dr. Fatma Gzara** and **Dr. Leia Minaker** at the University of Waterloo, who co-lead the research project. They will provide ongoing academic oversight, including weekly meetings to review progress and ensure alignment with project objectives. The interns will also participate in regular monthly check-in meetings with the **City of Waterloo** and the research team to discuss findings and coordinate next steps.

The project will use the **research infrastructure of the University of Waterloo**, including access to supervision, research support, and training provided by the academic team. Interns will be hired and managed through the University, ensuring that all research activities are conducted under appropriate academic oversight and ethical standards.

2.3.b. Description of the Partner Internship Environment

i. Please state the nature of the partner interaction: ☐ *Onsite* ☐ *Virtual* ☒ *Hybrid*

ii. Describe the working environment at the partner organization and the type and frequency of interactions between the intern(s) and employees. For example, what resources, facilities/equipment, and specialized training will the intern(s) have access to? If the intern(s) will work virtually, how will they be exposed to the activities and culture of the partner organization?

The interns will work within a collaborative research environment that integrates academic supervision with active engagement from municipal and industry partners. They will regularly interact with municipal planners, engineers, administrators, and developers as part of the data collection, validation, and consultation processes outlined in the project.

Interns will participate in structured meetings, interviews, and focus groups to document and analyze land development processes. They will also collaborate closely with the project's core research team and consultants involved in Value Stream Mapping, swim lane analysis, and harmonization framework development.

Work will take place in a hybrid setting combining on-site meetings and workshops with virtual collaboration for analysis and documentation. Interns will have access to research data, process mapping tools, and analysis software used by the project team. This environment will expose interns to both the academic and applied policy aspects of municipal process reform, providing practical experience in stakeholder engagement, data analysis, and process mapping.

2.4 PAST/OTHER MITACS PROJECTS

Is this application related to, or a continuation of, any previous or current Mitacs projects? ☐ *Yes* ☐ *No*

*If **Yes**, provide specifics about the relationship(s), including relevant project IT#(s). If the current project is a continuation of prior work, briefly describe how it meaningfully furthers what has been previously achieved.*

Click or tap here to enter text.

2.5 ENGAGEMENT WITH INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES OR PARTNERS (IF APPLICABLE)

Projects that involve or impact Indigenous communities must comply with the Mitacs Indigenous Research Policy. Describe (1) Indigenous community support for the project, and their role in shaping its objectives/approach, (2) plans for Indigenous community access, use, and governance of resulting knowledge/data, and (3) the team background in Indigenous research, including planned training/mentorship the intern(s) will receive to address deficits in experience.

You may also submit 1-2 letter(s) of support from Indigenous Elders who are members of the partner community/communities and possess the authority to speak on community interests.

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2.6 INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY (IF APPLICABLE)

*Explain how this project supports the **creation and/or ownership of IP** for the partner organization. If the project provides **education or training about IP** for any of the participants, explain here.*

Note - come back to after more info from City of Waterloo

2.7 REFERENCES / SOURCES (IF APPLICABLE)

List any references you have cited in your proposal.

Click or tap here to enter text.

Appendix A: Application Guide

Introduction

All applicants must complete all sections of the application form. Please contact your Mitacs Advisor if you have questions. The approval criteria can be found in **Appendix B**. Individual projects are not expected to meet all the criteria. As you write your application, be sure to include information about those criteria that do apply to your project.

Application checklist (what you need to apply)

- ✓ This application form **completed and uploaded** to the RAP.
  - All participants (intern, partner organization, academic supervisor) must create accounts in RAP and sign off on the project within RAP.
- ✓ Office of Research Services (ORS) or equivalent signature on the proposal.
  - A signature template is provided as part of the RAP application process. The lead applicant on the proposal will be responsible for collecting the ORS or equivalent signature and uploading the signature page to RAP.
  - Your academic institution must sign off on this proposal once all sections of the RAP are complete and all participants have signed off on the application. Instructions are provided in RAP.

Eligibility

Mitacs funds **research** and **innovation** projects. The BSI program focuses on **innovation projects**. Innovation projects are expected to lead to changes or improvements for the partner and/or community through exploration, design, and implementation of efficiencies in business models, products, processes, or services. Proposals should describe how the project will lead to economic, health and/or social benefits for the partner organization and/or the community and society at large.

Intern eligibility
Eligible interns for projects involving non-academic (industry or NFP) partners are:

- college students (any program) who may do up to **three** four- to six-month internships
- undergraduate students (any program) who may do up to **three** four- to six-month internships
- university master's students who may do up to **six** four- to six-month internships
- PhD students who may do up to **twelve** four- to six-month internships
- postdoctoral fellows (at colleges or universities) who may do up to **nine** four- to six-months internships (a full three years of funding)

Academic supervisor eligibility
Eligible academic supervisors are:

- professors at Canadian universities who are eligible to receive Tri-Agency funds
- faculty or appropriate research staff at Canadian colleges

The academic supervisor who signs the proposal may choose to involve other qualified staff individuals at the academic institution, such as program or research staff or senior graduate students and/or postdocs in the hands-on supervision of interns. Any such collaborators or informal co-supervisors do not need to be listed on the application form as supervisors, but their roles in supporting the intern(s) should be described in the proposal.

Partner organization eligibility

Eligible partner organizations are:

- for-profit corporations in Canada
- NFP organizations in Canada
  - Eligible NFPs include charities, economic development organizations, industry associations, social welfare organizations, health organizations, foundations, and research centers/institutes.
  - Projects with an NFP partner must demonstrate an economic or productivity orientation, which must be described in the proposal.
- municipalities
- hospitals

Collaboration

Collaboration is an essential feature of many Mitacs projects. BSI projects may involve a collaboration between:

- an **academic institution** and a **non-academic partner organization** that participates in and contributes funds to the project.
- These projects may be built in four- to six-month internship units, each valued at:
  - $10,000 with a $5,000 contribution from the partner organization; or
  - $15,000 with a $7,500 contribution from the partner organization.

Collaboration with non-academic organizations

Projects involving non-academic partner organizations (i.e., companies, eligible not-for-profits [NFPs]) require a true collaboration between the intern, their academic supervisor and institution, and the partner organization. The non-academic partner organization is not just a financial sponsor of the project; they are expected to participate in the development and completion of the project alongside the intern(s). In-person interaction at the partner's location is required when feasible, but we recognize that due to pandemic restrictions, many organizations began working virtually, and that this mode of work continues in some fields as part of the new normal. If the non-academic partner organization does not have a physical location where the intern can interact with their staff, be sure to clearly describe plans for virtual interaction. It is also important to note that Mitacs projects are not work placements or traditional co-ops. Academic supervisors (and/or other members of the supervisory team at the academic institution) are expected to play an active role in advising the intern throughout the project.

Appendix B: Selection Criteria

Mitacs will review applications to ensure that minimum requirements for completeness and project eligibility are met. For information about this, please refer to the submission checklist below.

Mitacs will also assess the benefits of the project in terms of: the economic and societal impact; the development and deployment of talent; and the establishment and support of collaborations. A project does not need to demonstrate benefits in each category (project, talent, and collaboration) since strength in one category can make up for weakness in another. Projects that demonstrate little or no benefit across all categories will not be approved by Mitacs.

In addition to assessing the benefits of a project, each project will also be reviewed to ensure that it does not contain any unmanageable risks in the categories of: feasibility, loss of talent or international assets from Canada, economic and national security risks, and adverse effects on humans, animals, and/or the environment. Projects with high risks must demonstrate correspondingly high benefits to Canada and risk mitigation measures should be included in the proposal to justify approval by Mitacs.

While the selection process is not currently competitive, if funding does become limited, Mitacs will prioritize approval based on the potential cumulative benefits of the project.

Requirements for all projects

- ❑ The description of the why (the background), the what (the objectives), the how (the approach), the when (the timelines), and the project outputs (the deliverables), must be clear for all projects.

Requirements for all collaborations

- ❑ Objectives must be aligned with the knowledge, skills, expertise, and needs of all participants.
- ❑ Each party's roles and responsibilities must be clear to all signatories on the application.
- ❑ Each party's expectations on deliverables, priorities, and time sensitivities must be clear to all signatories on the application.
- ❑ Agreement on intellectual property rights, ownership, royalties must be clear to all signatories on the application.

Requirements for all internships

- ❑ A structure must be in place to provide academic support that is appropriate to the level of the intern(s).
- ❑ There must be sufficient support / supervision from the internship host at the partner organization.
- ❑ There must be sufficient capacity at the internship host to manage the planned number of interns.

Requirements for all projects involving Indigenous peoples or communities

- ❑ Project must have the support of the affected communities and those who have rights or a stake in the endeavor.
- ❑ Indigenous communities must have been involved in shaping the project from inception, and Elders and Knowledge Holders must have been directly engaged.
- ❑ There must be clear agreement on Indigenous communities' access, use, and governance of resulting knowledge and data.

- The project team must demonstrate the capacity to engage with Indigenous communities or partners in line with appropriate guidelines, principles, and policies (for more information please refer to our Indigenous Research Guidelines).

Project

Examples of how a project can demonstrate potential economic and societal impacts include, but are not limited to:

- creating or commercializing Canadian technology/intellectual property
- discovering new and broadly applicable knowledge
- enhancing Canadian productivity by developing new and improved processes
- supporting the entry of Canadian businesses into new domestic/international markets
- developing new business models for Canadian companies
- improving public services (e.g. transportation infrastructure, utilities, healthcare) in Canada
- contributing new solutions to community challenges in Canada
- addressing social or environmental issues important to Canadian society
- advancing new approaches to include under-represented groups in the knowledge economy
- working towards a more equal and equitable Canada
- implementing evidence-informed strategies to address a specific challenge

Talent

Examples of how a project can demonstrate the potential for supporting the development of a talented and skilled population include, but are not limited to:

- interns gaining specialized technical skills through access to and training on the use of specialized equipment and facilities
- training interns in research skills
- training interns in interdisciplinary teamwork
- training interns in community-based methodologies
- training interns in entrepreneurial/professional skills through structured activities
- creating opportunities for interns to apply their knowledge / skills and solve industry/real-world problems
- re-skilling/up-skilling interns to pursue new and emerging opportunities in Canada
- placing interns in positions (at Canadian companies or organizations) appropriate to their training/skills
- interns being introduced to new professional experiences/environments/contacts/networks in Canada
- supporting individuals from under-represented groups in the knowledge economy

Collaboration

Examples of how a project can demonstrate the anticipated benefits associated with collaboration include, but are not limited to:

- bringing people together to solve problems through complementary skills and expertise
- sharing access to data, facilities, instruments for mutual benefit
- exchanging knowledge among academia, industry, communities
- moving tacit knowledge into practice through interdisciplinary teamwork
- supporting long-term relationships between academia, industry, communities
- establishing new collaborations between academia, industry, communities
- attracting foreign investment, talent, and innovative companies to Canada

- creating partnerships with communities that are under-represented in the knowledge economy
- linking Canadian researchers to prominent research groups globally